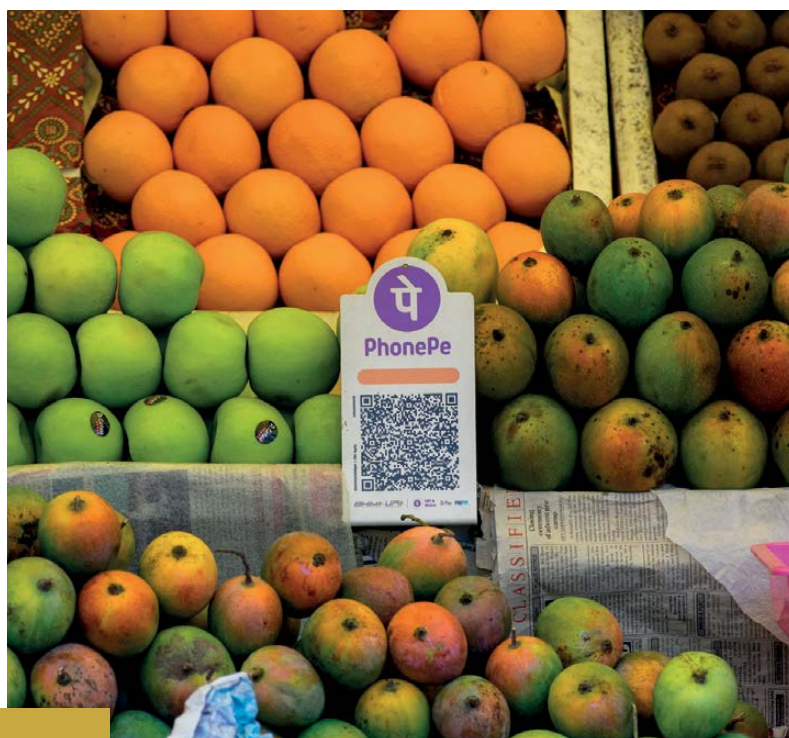




THE NEXT DECADE'S START-UPS WILL BE INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY-DRIVEN AND DEVICE-PRODUCT-DRIVEN

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or a fifth of the GDP, by 2026. And we're focussed on the goal of helping the digital economy touch \$1 trillion by around 2026-27. There's also the larger goal of making India a \$5-trillion economy by that time. I think we are on course for that. The past few years in particular—the investments made in semiconductors, electronics, the PLI (Production Linked Incentive) scheme, and SPECS (Scheme for Promotion of Manufacturing of Electronic Components and Semiconductors), in AI, and the strategic partnerships that the PM has drawn up with the US, Japan, South Korea, and the EU—these are all building blocks to what will be a trillion-plus digital economy in the coming years.

In this term, the government was beset with almost two and a half years of massive disruption in the Covid-19 pandemic. So,

really, if you look at a report card and extrapolate it over the last five years based on those two and a half years of productive growth that we had, and you then extrapolate that to the next five years, I think we can all safely assume that we will grow at significantly high rates. We can grow at 8 per cent or more easily in the coming five years. And that will take us very close to the goal of *Viksit Bharat* that the PM has set out.

In terms of the innovation ecosystem, which has about 100,000-plus start-ups and 111-odd unicorns, I see that by the time the next decade is out, the next wave of start-ups that are going to come are going to be intellectual property-driven, device-product-driven, and are going to come from semiconductors, electronic systems, quantum computing, high-performance computing, and AI. So I have no hesitation

in saying that the goal that we are working towards is about 1 million start-ups and almost 10,000 unicorns in the next decade.

The long and short of most of the conversation in tech today is a growing acknowledgement from the world that India will be among the nations that will shape the future of technology and innovation and be the provider of the most critical raw material—talent.

We are absolutely focussed on the PM's mission and vision that in areas like AI, semiconductors, Web 3, high-performance computing, quantum computing, scientific research, and adjacent areas, the talent that will propel and power the future decade of innovation—the India Techade of innovation—will be of high quality, globally competitive, hard-charging, and will come from Indian institutions.

I have been in the tech industry for three and a half decades. As a veteran Indian techie, I can say that this is certainly the most exciting time to be in Indian tech. It is certainly the most exciting time to be a young Indian in the history of independent India, and I see only an absolutely limitless future for the growth of our economy, our technology, and our innovation economy. I see the force, this very ambivalent and shy India, this underperforming India that was a narrative pre-2014, transforming steadily in the last 10 years and certainly definitely in the next 10 years into an unstoppable force and unstoppable India. We will end up with *Viksit Bharat*, a developed India for future generations. **BT**

As told to Nidhi Singal. The author is Minister of State for Skill Development and Entrepreneurship; Electronics and Information Technology; and Ministry of Jal Shakti. Views are personal